

Anniversary



SUMMARY

The speaker, Ted Hughes himself, describes seeing his mother surrounded by feathers made of fire and getting taller. He pictures her every year on May 13th, the anniversary of her death, alongside her sister, Miriam. All Hughes has to do is pick up the page ripped from a diary where his brother wrote down that their mother had died and it's like she and Miriam are suddenly right in front of him. His mother is now the same height as Miriam. In the afterlife, where it's like it's always Sunday morning, they walk together listening to the early morning birdsong as it echoes above them. The work of the universe surrounds them, energy pulsing and flaring as new things are made and other things are destroyed. It's like a colorful curtain of light running through their feathers.

Hughes's mother is telling Miriam all about her life—which really means she's telling Miriam all about *Hughes's* life. Her voice ripples as though reverberating through a deep forest gorge. She shows Miriam a mark on her dress and explains that's the water stain from a time she had to pull Hughes out of a reservoir. Then she points out a horse that she rode far across a field just to bring her son a new pen. And here's the pen itself, which she sacrificed for him. She points out the multiple weddings of Hughes and his brother, to which she wasn't invited. Now she's tossing red-hot coals with her bare hands to see where Hughes had fallen down again for the third time. She can't help but laugh until she cries. Miriam died when she was only 18, and she's astonished, almost saintly, hearing about all the things she wasn't around for. Hughes's mother shows her sister all her worries, which she counts out like rosary beads, trying on one after the other like a pair of shoes or a dress. She wore those worries all the time, and she liked it like that. She spent a lot of her time just sitting and looking out the window, perfectly content just to know that Hughes and his brother were out there living their lives. She still feels like that now, in fact, and tells Miriam to look at Hughes.

The two women stop for a moment, at the edge of the afterlife, where the stars are like tiny sparkling dewdrops. They're watching Hughes. His mother, who died more recently, looks more vibrant than Miriam, with her bright red hair and her ethereal, olive skin. Miriam, meanwhile, is now a transparent flame at her side. Shimmering light pulses in the feathers in their wings. Hughes's mother's face is wet and shiny, as if she was trying to spot her son through a strong wind. Hughes does this (writing, living, elegizing) for her.

She uses Hughes like an instrument—her love for Hughes is really just a way for her to feel her sorrowful love for his brother more intensely. It's like Hughes is just a shadow, while

he's the real deal.

Once, when Hughes reached her after walking a mile through the fields, he discovered that she was crying over his brother. She had believed it was his brother coming towards her the whole time.



THEMES



GRIEF AND MEMORY

In this autobiographical poem, Ted Hughes [elegizes](#) his mother on the anniversary of her death. It isn't hard for Hughes to bring his mother back to life in his mind: all he has to do is "lift / The torn-off diary page" where his brother recorded the date of her death, and she appears. In fact, his mother seems to become *more* vivid in memory than she was in life: Hughes sees her draped in "feathers of flame," walking alongside her sister, Miriam, who died many years earlier. Hughes glorifies both women in his grief, illustrating the way the dead often get mythologized in the memories of those they left behind. For Hughes, his mother becomes a larger-than-life figure whose lingering presence is both a comfort and a burden.

As the poem begins, Hughes notes that his mother is "now as tall as Miriam," an image suggesting that his mother's legacy has grown in his mind in the years since her death. In the same vein, he describes her "Red Indian hair," her "piping" voice, and "her skin / So strangely olive and other-worldly"; her features are striking, no longer of this world, as she talks to her sister "In the perpetual Sunday Morning / Of everlasting" (that is, the afterlife). Miriam, meanwhile, is now "Madonna-like with pure wonder" to hear Hughes's mother talk about her life and children. He imagines her and his mother watching Hughes and his brother from beyond the grave, "their feathers throb[bing] softly, iridescent."

This is no hazy portrait. Clearly, his mother's presence hasn't dulled with time but remained vivid and arresting. She and Miriam are like towering, fiery angels whose intense love transcends the grave. Hughes describes them "looking at" him from the afterlife, his mother explaining the satisfaction she got—and "still" gets—from simply knowing he and his brother "were somewhere."

Yet as the halo of flame around his mother "grows taller," Hughes's complicated feelings about her seem to become sharper and more painful as well. He can't escape her presence, which means he also can't escape old grievances that defined his relationship with her. More specifically, he still can't step out from "the shadow cast" by his brother, whom Hughes argues she favored. Though he envisions his mother "looking at" him

from beyond the grave, he ends the poem by revealing that, once again, she is only *seeing* his brother.

Memory, then, becomes a kind of double-edged sword in Hughes's grief. While the poem reaffirms how much his mother cared about the speaker and his brother, it also hints that, for Hughes, the memory of her love is as painful as it is comforting.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-17
- Lines 30-58



LOVE, RIVALRY, AND RESENTMENT

Although "Anniversary" has many tender details, Ted Hughes doesn't shy away from illustrating the more complicated aspects of his relationship with his mother. Her love was genuine and profound, the poem implies, but it could also be all-consuming, even smothering—and her supposed preference for Hughes's brother pushed Hughes himself even further away. Hughes's poem thus memorializes his mother while, at the same time, revealing how anger, favoritism, and resentment often kept them at a distance.

Hughes remembers his mother as a woman who loved deeply and was, in turn, deeply loved. He imagines her reuniting with her own beloved sister Miriam in the afterlife, and catching her up on the children Miriam never got to meet. In these imagined conversations, Hughes presents himself and his brother as the main source of their mother's happiness and fulfillment. Though her own day-to-day life didn't seem particularly exciting, she derived tremendous satisfaction from simply knowing that he and his brother were out in the world, living their lives.

Because her happiness was so wrapped up in her sons' lives, however, it could be challenging for them (or, at least, for Hughes), to feel as if their lives were ever truly their own. "[H]er life," Hughes says, "was mine," an admission conveying both the depth of his mother's life and how burdensome—how laden with expectations—that love could feel. Even now, Hughes says, "I do this for her": he feels compelled, for his mother's sake, to write about his mother.

Hughes's mother clearly sacrificed a lot for her children—and she seems to have made that *known* to her sons, too. Hughes imagines her in the afterlife telling Miriam about pulling a young Hughes out of a reservoir, staining her dress in the process, and how she once rode through the countryside just to bring him a pen. At the same time, she notes how her children seem to have shut her out: she takes care to mention "the mass marriages of him and his brother / Where I was not once a guest."

Readers can sense some resentment here regarding the fact that neither Hughes nor his brother allowed her to fully be a

part of their adult lives. Recall that Hughes is imagining this whole scene, however; her snide comment about not being invited to their weddings suggests his *own* lingering guilt for how he treated her.

And yet, this resentment seems to have gone both ways. Although Hughes describes several ways his mother expressed her love, and he accepts how she was always "looking towards me" to find meaning in her life, he understands, bitterly, that the person she *really* longed for was his brother. Her love for Hughes himself was just practice, a way to "tune finer / Her weeping love for my brother." In other words, she was unable to love Hughes simply for his own sake. Her real affection—and approval—always seemed to go to his brother instead. In life, her favoritism, and Hughes's resentment, pushed him away emotionally.

Illustrating this, Hughes recounts an incident when his mother saw him moving towards her across a mile-long field and allowed herself to believe, or pretend, "for all that distance" that he was actually his brother. This "distance" evokes the emotional space between them. And yet, he accepts his obligation, as a son, to "do this for her" and honor her memory the best way that he can—by writing this elegy.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 3-5
- Lines 15-30
- Lines 37-58



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-5

*My mother in ...
... there they are.*

Ted Hughes begins "Anniversary" with a surreal description of his mother. She appears, Hughes says, "in her feathers of flame": a phrase that suggests she is framed by fiery wings. She's like an angel, perhaps, but not one with fluffy white feathers and a quaint golden halo. The fricative [alliteration](#) of "feathers of flame" evokes the flickering of those flames, which transform Hughes's mother into an imposing (maybe even frightening) presence. Indeed, she "grows taller," Hughes continues: a nod not to literal growth but to the idea that she has [metaphorically](#) become a more towering figure in Hughes's mind.

Line 2 then introduces an important date: May 13th. This is the anniversary of the poem's title, but it's not clear yet of *what*. The speaker withholds the answer for another three lines, generating suspense. That suspense is drawn out through the use of [caesurae](#). Each caesura forces the reader to pause, to take an extra beat, as with the full stops in lines 2 and 3:

Grows taller. Every May Thirteenth
I see her with her sister Miriam. I lift

Finally, in line 5, Hughes reveals what's so important about May 13th: this is the day his mother died. (Hughes's mother, Edith, died on May 13th, 1969.) The date has been recorded on a page torn out of a diary (a British term for a daybook or calendar), having been "jotted" down by Hughes's brother. When Hughes goes to "lift" the page, he sees his mother and his aunt, Miriam, appear before him.

- Some context: Miriam died at the age of 18, well before Hughes was born. According to Hughes, a vision of Miriam would often appear to his mother as a consoling presence shortly before someone close to her died. "My mother described her as being made of flame," he said. "As if she were covered with many-colored feathers of soft, pouring flame." Hughes is clearly drawing from these real memories here and throughout the poem.

Hughes presents all this quite matter-of-factly. The language throughout these opening lines is remarkably casual given their subject. Hughes doesn't say that his brother somberly recorded the date of death, but simply that he "jotted" it down—a word that makes it seem almost like an afterthought. The phrase "Ma died today" is similarly blunt and straightforward; there's nothing dramatic or particularly emotional about this recording.

Hughes also doesn't seem surprised or astonished to see his dead mother and her sister. Instead, the apparitions are described plainly, as though their appearance is natural and expected. The speaker's mother is dead, and yet, the speaker's mother is here; that's simply how it is. It's unclear whether Hughes deliberately conjures his mother in his mind (i.e., by flipping to that "torn-off diary page") or if she arrives unbidden, pulled by the force of his grief. Either way, it sounds as though Hughes has come to anticipate this vision every year.

LINES 6-10

*She is now ...
... in their orbits.*

Hughes says that his mother, years after her death, "is now as tall as Miriam." On one level, this refers to the [metaphorical](#) space she takes up in her son's mind: her legacy now looms just as large as Miriam's does. This also might suggest that Hughes's mother—who died an older woman—now appears before her son as a younger, more vibrant, and, yes, physically taller version of herself.

Hughes then begins to sketch out his vision of the afterlife. Wherever Miriam and Edith are, it is "the perpetual Sunday Morning / Of everlasting." This doesn't seem to be Heaven,

exactly, at least in a biblical sense. But it does have *heavenly* qualities. It seems peaceful and serene; it is an eternal, or "everlasting," realm.

The sounds of these lines evoke a pleasant, calm environment. Listen, for example, to the whispery [sibilance](#) and smooth /l/ [alliteration](#) and [consonance](#) of lines 8-9:

Of everlasting, they are strolling together
Listening to the larks

These soft, lilting sounds add a hush to the poem. This realm seems calm and peaceful, filled with the gentle chatter of birds. The reference to "Sunday Morning" also [alludes](#) to Christianity: Sunday is the Lord's Day, when Jesus Christ was resurrected. That this is a "perpetual Sunday Morning" conveys not just the pleasant, leisurely atmosphere but also the idea that Hughes's mother and aunt have been spiritually resurrected in this place. To that end, note that larks, songbirds that sing very early in the day, are often [symbols](#) of spiritual awakening, the passage to Heaven, or even Christ himself. Miriam and Edith are "strolling together" outside the mortal realm and out of Hughes's reach. They've been reunited where the dead live on.

Note, too, that Hughes is writing in the present tense. His vision is *continuously* unfolding. Within the world of the poem, Miriam and Edith are *still* "strolling together." Hughes communicates the idea of eternal renewal through the use of present participles like "strolling," "listening," and "ringing." These are actions without end. Those lark songs ring "in their orbits": in a loop that never ends.

LINES 10-14

*The work of ...
... in their feathers.*

In lines 10-14, the poem zooms out, moving from Miriam and Edith strolling together to the birds "in their orbits" above them to, finally, a surreal vision of the "cosmos" itself. The afterlife, as Hughes imagines it, is still a *part* of the natural world, of the universe.

The "everlasting" realm is linked to the cosmic cycles of "creation and destruction of matter / And of anti-matter." All matter (and "anti-matter") is recycled within the processes of "creation and destruction" that make up the universe. *This* is the "work of the cosmos" Hughes mentions: the circle of life and death, of which his mother and Miriam are now a part. Indeed, their new forms are infused with the energy of the universe, which "[p]ulses and flares, shudders and fades" like the "Northern Lights" (the aurora borealis) in the women's "feathers."

[Sibilance](#) and fricative [alliteration](#) bring the [imagery](#) to life, evoking the flicking of all that light and energy:

Pulses and flares, shudders and fades

The afterlife isn't simply a serene, peaceful place, then: it is also part of the cycle of life that guides the universe.

LINES 15-19

*My mother is ...
... from the reservoir.*

Miriam died young, so Hughes's mother is filling her in on all that she missed. But Edith is not simply talking about herself: "[H]er life," Hughes writes, "was mine." That is, his mother's life was inseparably bound up with his own. Her identity was wrapped up in and dependent upon her children.

Hughes presents this point as an offhand remark, sandwiching it between two other clauses in one of the longest lines of the poem:

About her life, **which was mine**. Her voice comes,
piping,

A hint of resentment slips out here. This moment is a crack in the [elegy](#) and an early indication that the loss of his mother is complicated for Hughes because her presence was at times burdensome. The sounds of line 16 might very subtly hint at Hughes's indignation and desire for autonomy via the [assonance](#) of "life," "mine," and "piping": "I," "I," "I."

Hughes's mother's voice then flows out, as "Down a deep gorge of woodland echoes." It's as if his mother's voice is pouring out of and reverberating off of the earth itself. On the one hand, this conveys the depth and power of her voice in her son's mind. This mention of the earth also ties back to the idea that the afterlife is still part of nature, or of the universe. Hughes's mother is separate from the world of the living, but she is still part of the cycle of life and death.

She then points out a stain on her dress: "the water-line" from where she had to wade into a reservoir to save her son from drowning. The stain is a [symbol](#) of the depth of her love: a physical reminder that she put herself in danger for her child. At the same time, the fact that she wants Miriam (and the reader) to "look" at this hints that she wants some sort of recognition for or acknowledgment of her sacrifice.

LINES 20-24

*And that is ...
... on the altar.*

Hughes's mother continues giving examples of how dedicated she was to her son. She points out a horse she rode "[t]hrough the brick wall" (presumably, either over a low brick wall or through an opening in the wall) and across the moor just "[t]o bring him a new pen."

These lines reference the Yorkshire landscapes of Hughes's

childhood, when his family lived in Mytholmroyd and Mexborough. As Hughes's mother describes herself here, she strenuously supported him in his early ambitions to become a poet, going out of her way to bring him what he needed. The [enjambment](#) of these lines mimics the urgency of her task, as each line quickly flows into the next:

And that is the horse on which I galloped
Through the brick wall
And out over the heather simply
To bring him a new pen. [...]

The lack of [caesurae](#) here (until the period after "pen") also means so there's no opportunity to pause. The quick rhythm of these lines makes Hughes's mother seem like a heroic figure, sailing over a brick wall on a galloping horse and riding hard across the fields of heather to reach her son. This, Hughes suggests, is how she saw herself—as his defender and champion.

Because these lines are written entirely in her voice, Hughes doesn't personally comment on whether or not this was accurate. Clearly, he recognized her devotion to him. But line 23 begins to introduce the possibility that maybe she was a little *too* self-sacrificing. "This is the pen / I laid on the altar" suggests a *literal* sacrifice. Perhaps it even implies that her own literary ambitions were put aside in order to support her children.

LINES 24-29

*And these ...
... the third time.*

If Hughes's mother sounded slightly resentful as she described all she did to support her son, she sounds outright bitter by line 24. She wasn't invited to either of her sons' marriages, she tells Miriam. She implies that her sacrifices were never fully acknowledged or appreciated while she was alive. After all, she was excluded from these major life events, even shunted out of their lives altogether.

Her speech ends in a [caesura](#), punctuated with a period:

Where I was not once a guest." [...]

There's a damning finality to this pause. Maybe, despite their accomplishments, Hughes and his brother really weren't very good sons. (This might be why Hughes feels obliged to honor her memory now, in this [elegy](#).)

"Then suddenly," Hughes continues, she rakes her fingers through "the red coals," revealing or uncovering the place "where I had fallen / For the third time." Hughes's mother seems to stirring up the repeated tragedies that knocked Hughes to the ground. The poem withholds personal details from Hughes's biography here: namely, the death of his first

wife, Sylvia Plath, and then his partner, Assia Wevill and their daughter, Shura. The loss of his mother is the third time Hughes has found himself undone by grief.

The mention of scattering coals might further be an [allusion](#) to the Bible, perhaps specifically to Ezekiel 10:2, when God instructs a "man clothed in linen" to fill his hands with "burning coals" and "scatter them over the city" of Jerusalem. In this passage, the burning coals reflect God's wrath; the coals will purify the city of its sin. Hughes's mother might be both judging and absolving her son for his own "sins"—his various "falls" from grace.

LINES 29-33

*She laughs ...
... all she missed.*

After "scattering the red coals with her fingers" and revealing how Hughes has, for a third time, been laid low by tragedy, Hughes's mother begins to laugh. She laughs "[h]elplessly," until she begins to cry.

It's unclear if she is relishing her son's pain—perhaps as a kind of payback for the ways he slighted her—or if she is laughing at herself, and how, despite her diligence and care, she was unable to protect him from loss and grief. The poem doesn't give any easy answers, and the speaker doesn't interject to offer an opinion of his own.

Instead, he turns his attention briefly to Miriam, whom he now reveals died when she was just 18 years old. Although she passed away before Hughes was born, he's chosen to enshrine her memory here. She appears almost saintly: Hughes calls her "Madonna-like," a [simile](#) comparing her to the Virgin Mary. She seems to represent a certain purity and innocence—a girl who never got to experience adulthood for herself. She's astonished by everything her sister has told her, and is practically glowing "with pure wonder / To hear of all she missed."

LINES 33-37

*Now my mother ...
... to wear best."*

"Now," Hughes writes in line 33, "my mother / Shows her the rosary prayers of unending worry." After the reference to Christian iconography in line 32 ("Madonna-like"), Hughes again pulls from religious language to make his point. The "rosary beads" are a [metaphor](#) for his mother's "unending" string of anxieties, which she held close and counted on. She was devoted, he's saying, to her "worry" the way a person might be devoted to prayer.

This is a pretty snide remark, since it suggests that she was inclined to worry even when there wasn't anything to worry about. Worse, she might have even been a bit self-righteous about it.

Using a [simile](#), Hughes then says that his mother's fixations and

anxieties were "[l]ike pairs of shoes, or one dress after another," which she would try on and then discard. The poem implies that she liked it this way and that there was something gratifying about "wearing" her worries for all to see. For an [elegy](#), this isn't a totally flattering portrait of Hughes's mother!

LINES 37-42

*And: "Much of ...
... Look."*

Once again speaking in his mother's voice, Hughes reveals that her sons were the source of her day-to-day happiness and contentment. Despite all she sacrificed, and despite the ways in which she was excluded from her sons' lives, she genuinely relished "simply sitting at the window / Watching the horizon," because she knew that her children "were somewhere" out there. By the end of her life, it seems, she didn't have wild ambitions or too many regrets. What was important to her was the knowledge that her children had grown up and were living their lives.

It's a lovely thought and a testament to the ways in which she was a loving and devoted mother. But it also raises the issue that Hughes introduced earlier in the stanza, in line 16. Could her life really be *hers*, or his life his own, if she insisted on living vicariously through him?

Lines 38-41 are filled with [alliteration](#) ("simply sitting," "window / Watching [...] Wonderful it was," "were"), [assonance](#) ("simply sitting," "It still is"), and [consonance](#) ("knowing," "somewhere"). As a result, the lines simply *sound* repetitive. In particular, Hughes crams in several words that start with /w/: *was*, *window*, *watching*, *wonderful*. One could interpret the progression of similar-sounding words as a representation of the days and days his mother sat looking out the window, with little else happening or changing. The [diacope](#) of "day after day" adds to the sense of endless, monotonous time passing by.

Line 42 is then the shortest line in the whole poem, made up of just one word: "Look." This is the second time Hughes's mother has instructed Miriam (and, by extension, the reader) to look at something (earlier, she said to "look" at the stain on her dress). But now, instead of asking Miriam to look at *her*, Hughes's mother is instructing her to look off into the distance. One can think of all the white space after the word "Look," which is the final line of this stanza, as the space which now exists between Hughes and his mother. The reader's eyes have to jump across an extra line to get to the start of the next stanza, just as Hughes's mother instructs Miriam to look out from the "brink" of the realm of the dead towards the speaker in the land of the living.

LINES 43-48

*And they pause, ...
... flame beside her.*

Miriam and Edith "pause, on the brink," or the edge, of the

afterlife. The [enjambment](#) after the word "brink" is fitting, the word itself becoming like a cliff at the end of line 43:

And they pause, on the **brink**
Of the starry dew. [...]

Instead of stopping or pausing, the poem leaps right into line 44: "Of the starry dew. They are looking at me." (That phrase, "starry dew," may be borrowed from Percy Bysshe Shelley's poem, "[Adonais](#)," which is also an elegy.)

It's an eerie moment: Hughes can feel the subjects of the poem looking out at him from beyond the grave. The image suggests the way that no one really can control the way loved ones live on in their hearts and minds after they're gone.

Next, Hughes uses visual [imagery](#) to reveal what his mother looked like in life and contrasts her appearance with her sister's. Edith is "darker," or more vibrant/solid-looking, because she hasn't been dead quite so long. Hughes can still clearly spot her "Red Indian hair," and recognizes the "olive" tone of her skin. The way he describes her complexion ("So strangely olive and other-wordly") suggests there was something ethereal about her even when she was still alive.

Miriam, however, is "sheer flame beside her." She's shed her mortal form entirely, it seems. She's now a tower of pale fire, as if her energy and essence have grown purer and more elemental in the years since her death.

LINES 49-52

*Their feathers throb ...
... this for her.*

As the sisters look out towards the speaker, "Their feathers throb softly, iridescent." It's a striking, contemplative moment. With its soft and [sibilant](#) consonants, the sounds of this line also enhance its visual [imagery](#):

Their feathers **throb** softly, iridescent.

The pattern of **stressed** syllables even mimics the way these feathers seem to pulse and "throb":

Their **feathers throb** softly, [...]

Hughes's mother's face seems to shine, "glistening, / As if she held it to the skyline wind." Looking out towards her son, her face is sparkling, as though streaked with tears from staring directly into a strong wind. It's unclear if she's happy or sad, however.

Hughes's feelings are complicated, too. There's real love and tenderness in this stanza, as well as yearning. Hughes does seem to miss his mother deeply. At the same time, that firm, full-stop [caesura](#) in the middle of line 52 creates a loaded pause

in which one can feel the weight of these women staring at Hughes, perhaps with some sense of expectation:

Looking towards me. I do this for her.

Seeming to feel this himself, Hughes then admits that he feels obligated to "do this for her." By "this," he likely means writing this very poem. In other words, he feels he owes it to his mother to honor her memory and to memorialize her in his work. And yet, he can't forget the more difficult parts of their relationship. Remembering his mother brings him comfort, but it triggers sadness and frustration, too.

LINES 53-58

*She is using ...
... think me him.*

Hughes ends the poem's third stanza by declaring that he does "this"—that he's writing this poem—"for her." He begins the poem's final section by declaring what she is doing "this"—"Looking towards me"—for: "to tune finer / Her weeping love for my brother." That is, Hughes's mother is *looking* at him, then, but she isn't really *seeing* him. Instead, he [metaphorically](#) compares himself to an instrument that his mother is using to "tune," or refine, her love for Hughes's *brother*. That this love is "weeping" suggests that she is grieving being separated from her other son. (Indeed, Hughes's elder brother, Gerald, emigrated from England to Australia shortly after World War II.)

Another metaphor underscores the way Hughes is just an approximation of her favorite son: he is "the shadow cast" by the child she wants to be "Looking towards." In lines 53-55 ("She is using [...] this approach."), Hughes thus comes face-to-face with the sense of his own inadequacy in his mother's eyes. He feels as if he's been pitted against his own brother by his mother's favoritism. His mother's love is powerful, felt even after her death, but it's also a constant reminder that he was never quite able to step into his brother's shoes.

Note that the final two stanzas of the poem are tercets: they are made up of three lines each. They are the most formal-looking stanzas in the whole poem. They're also mirror images of each other. Lines 53 and 56 are both [enjambéd](#) and lack [caesurae](#):

She is using me to tune **finer**
[...]
As when I came a mile over fields and **walls**

Lines 54 and 57 each have a caesura and are end-stopped:

Her weeping love for my **brother, through** mine,
[...]
Towards **her, and** found her weeping for him—

And, finally, lines 55 and 58 (the final line of the poem) lack caesurae and are end-stopped:

As if I were the shadow cast by this approach.
[...]
Able for all that distance to think me him.

Formally, this mirroring reflects the doubling that Hughes describes as he explains his rivalry with his brother.

Hughes digs into this rivalry in the poem's closing lines. Once, Hughes explains, he walked a mile toward her "over fields and walls," a physical distance that reflects the emotional space between them. But when he reached her, he "found her weeping" for his brother instead. From a distance, she'd tricked herself into believing Hughes was his brother, only to be crushed when Hughes himself came near and shattered her delusion.

In a sense, the poem mirrors this story: Hughes is figuratively walking towards his mother by writing this poem, trying to get closer to her and bridge the distance between the worlds of the living and the dead. Readers likely get the sense, in the end, that the result is the same: even as Hughes envisions his mother looking towards him from the edge of the afterlife, she is trying to see his brother.



THE LARKS

Larks are a type of bird known for singing very early in the morning, often before dawn. As such, they're often [symbols](#) of daybreak in literature. They're also sometimes linked with Christ himself as well as a kind of *spiritual* dawn or movement from the earthly to the heavenly world.

Hughes nods to that symbolism here in mentioning that his mother and Miriam "are strolling together / Listening to the larks / Ringing in their orbits." Given that the women "the perpetual Sunday Morning / Of everlasting," it makes sense that they're be listening to a bird associated with the dawn! The larks' presence reflects the idea that this is a place in which these women's spirits or souls have arisen.

More specifically, Hughes says that the larks' song is "Ringing in their orbits." An orbit brings to mind the movement of the planets, linking this heaven-like place to the "cosmos." An orbit doesn't have a clear beginning or end; likewise, the singing—the afterlife—goes on and on.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 7-10:** "In the perpetual Sunday Morning / Of everlasting, they are strolling together / Listening to the larks / Ringing in their orbits."



SYMBOLS



THE PEN

The pen [symbolizes](#) the young Ted Hughes's literary ambitions. It's the poet's instrument, the tool of his trade, and it represents his commitment to his art. Hughes's mother describes to her sister, Miriam, how once she rode a horse through the countryside and "out over the heather simply / To bring him a new pen." This is her way of explaining how she championed the young Hughes as an artist. She understood the pen's power (that is, she knows it's not "just" a pen) and went out of her way to deliver it to him. And this is the same pen which, she says, "I laid on the altar." Here, Hughes's mother doesn't mean a literal altar. She's speaking in a symbolic register about sacrifice: she is offering up the pen. This seems to stand in for all the other sacrifices she made for her children over the years, perhaps even putting aside her own literary ambitions to support her son's artistic talent.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 20-24:** "And that is the horse on which I galloped / Through the brick wall / And out over the heather simply / To bring him a new pen. This is the pen / I laid on the altar."



POETIC DEVICES

CONSONANCE

"Anniversary" doesn't use [rhyme](#) or a steady [meter](#), but it's still a very lyrical poem. This is in large part thanks to [consonance](#) (and, sometimes, [alliteration](#)), which make the poem's language sound more intense, musical, and memorable.

In stanza 1, for example, /f/ alliteration highlights the image of the speaker's mother surrounded by "feathers of flame." Those fricative sounds might also evoke the flickering of a flame itself. Later, soft /s/ and lilting /l/ sounds make the image of the afterlife more reassuring. There's something hushed and comforting about the sounds of this passage:

In the perpetual Sunday Morning
Of everlasting, they are strolling together
Listening to the larks

In this way, the poem's sounds often enhance its [imagery](#). For another example, listen to the pounding /d/ alliteration and consonance of line 17:

Down a deep gorge of woodland echoes:

These sounds evoke the power of Hughes's mother's "piping"

voice as it "echoes" through the afterlife.

Hughes also uses consonance to control the emotional register of the poem. In lines 25-30, for example, [sibilance](#) (as well /f/, /th/, and /sh/ sounds, which are often considered sibilant in their own right) illustrates his mother's anger and grief as well as his own sadness. Speaking about himself in the voice of his mother, he writes:

Are the mass marriages of him and his brother
Where I was not once a guest." Then suddenly
She is scattering the red coals with her fingers
To find where I had fallen
For the third time. She laughs
Helplessly till she weeps [...]

All these hissing, slippery, hushed sounds evoke both bitter anger and deep sadness.

Where Consonance appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "feathers," "flame"
- **Line 2:** "Thirteenth"
- **Line 3:** "sister," "lift"
- **Line 4:** "torn," "brother," "jotted"
- **Line 5:** "today," "there," "they"
- **Line 7:** "Sunday"
- **Line 8:** "everlasting," "strolling"
- **Line 9:** "Listening," "larks"
- **Line 10:** "cosmos"
- **Line 11:** "Creation"
- **Line 13:** "Pulses," "flares," "shudders," "fades"
- **Line 14:** "Like," "Lights," "feathers"
- **Line 17:** "Down," "deep," "woodland"
- **Line 18:** "dark," "dress"
- **Line 19:** "dragged"
- **Line 25:** "mass," "marriages"
- **Line 26:** "was," "once," "guest," "suddenly"
- **Line 27:** "She," "scattering," "coals," "fingers"
- **Line 28:** "find," "fallen"
- **Line 29:** "For," "laughs"
- **Line 30:** "Helplessly," "weeps"
- **Line 38:** "was," "simply," "sitting," "window"
- **Line 39:** "Watching"
- **Line 40:** "Wonderful," "was"
- **Line 41:** "Knowing," "somewhere"
- **Line 46:** "skin"
- **Line 47:** "So," "strangely," "olive"
- **Line 49:** "softly," "iridescent"
- **Line 50:** "face," "glistening"

CAESURA

Instead of finding a natural break at the end of a line, Hughes often inserts a brief pause in the middle of a line with a comma,

period, or em-dash (—). On a simple level, this frequent use of [caesura](#) controls the poem's rhythms. "Anniversary" is written in [free verse](#) with frequent [enjambments](#), but caesura keeps the poem from every feeling too fluid or out of control. Hughes fills the poem with weighty pauses, creating a straightforward, matter-of-fact tone.

For example, note the full-stop caesuras in lines 2-3 and 29-30:

Grows taller. Every May Thirteenth
I see her with her sister Miriam. I lift
[...]
To find where I had fallen
For the third time. She laughs
Helplessly till she weeps. Miriam

In both instances, the caesurae also add a sense of firmness or finality to Hughes's statements. Hughes sounds authoritative.

Caesurae can also create a kind of [parallelism](#) within a line when they balance two images or statements, as in line 13:

Pulses and flares, shudders and fades

Think about how this line might read differently if it were written like a list: "Pulses, flares, shudders, and fades." The caesura creates two "groups" of images that contrast and play off each other. It's also an effective tool for generating emphasis, as in lines 22-23:

And out over the heather simply
To bring him a new pen. This is the pen

The repetition of the word "pen" on either side of the caesura makes it clear that there's something significant about *this* pen, which becomes [symbolic](#) of everything that Hughes's mother sacrificed for her son's artistic development. One can even read the pause as a space in which Hughes's mother takes out or holds up the pen itself for Miriam to see.

Where Caesura appears in the poem:

- **Line 2:** "taller. Every"
- **Line 3:** "Miriam. I"
- **Line 5:** "today"—and"
- **Line 8:** "everlasting, they"
- **Line 10:** "orbits. The"
- **Line 13:** "flares, shudders"
- **Line 16:** "life, which," "mine. Her," "comes, piping"
- **Line 18:** "water-line, dark," "dress, look"
- **Line 23:** "pen. This"
- **Line 24:** "altar. And"
- **Line 26:** "guest." Then"
- **Line 29:** "time. She"

- **Line 30:** "weeps. Miriam"
- **Line 33:** "missed. Now"
- **Line 35:** "shoes, or"
- **Line 36:** "thing," she"
- **Line 37:** "best." And: "Much"
- **Line 39:** "horizon. Truly"
- **Line 40:** "was, day"
- **Line 41:** "somewhere. It"
- **Line 43:** "pause, on"
- **Line 44:** "dew. They"
- **Line 45:** "mother, darker"
- **Line 46:** "hair, her"
- **Line 52:** "me. I"
- **Line 54:** "brother, through"
- **Line 57:** "her, and"

IMAGERY

"Anniversary" is filled with striking [imagery](#). Hughes's encounter with the spirits of his mother and aunt is very visual—he *sees* them under the "torn-off diary page," and his use of imagery makes sure the reader can see them, too.

Though the reader understands that Miriam and Hughes's mother are both dead, there's nothing shadowy about them. Instead, the poem presents them as bright, fiery apparitions. Hughes's mother is surrounded by "feathers of flame" (which might be a reference to angel-like wings) and has grown "taller." She has shed some of the limits of her mortal form, it seems, her increase in size reflecting how large she looms in Hughes's memory.

Hughes also uses imagery when describing the realm of the dead ("the perpetual Sunday Morning / Of everlasting"). This place seems just as lush and vibrant as the living world—filled with "larks / Ringing in their orbits." His mother and Miriam can hear those birds, and their voices carry as through a forest, "piping" like a flute "[d]own a deep gorge of woodland echoes." All of these sensory details make it seem like these ghosts have sprung up out of the natural world. They are like powerful and beautiful angels, with light and colors "puls[ing] and flar[ing]" through their feathers.

Imagery sketches out what Hughes's mother looked like when she was alive as well. The reader learns of her "Red Indian hair" and her "strangely olive" skin. In fact, lines 46-47 suggest that there was something ethereal—"other-worldly"—about her even when she was alive.

Now that she's passed on, her relative proximity to life makes her "darker" than her sister, Miriam, who has become a pillar of "sheer flame beside her." Something happens, it seems, the further these ghosts get from life. But instead of fading away, their spirit becomes purer, more *elemental*.

Where Imagery appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** "My mother in her feathers of flame / Grows taller."
- **Line 4:** "The torn-off diary page"
- **Lines 9-10:** "Listening to the larks / Ringing in their orbits."
- **Lines 13-14:** "Pulses and flares, shudders and fades / Like the Northern Lights in their feathers."
- **Lines 16-17:** "Her voice comes, piping, / Down a deep gorge of woodland echoes:"
- **Line 27:** "She is scattering the red coals with her fingers"
- **Lines 43-44:** "the brink / Of the starry dew."
- **Lines 45-50:** "darker with her life, / Her Red Indian hair, her skin / So strangely olive and other-worldly, / Miriam now sheer flame beside her. / Their feathers throb softly, iridescent. / My mother's face is glistening"

SIMILE

The [similes](#) in "Anniversary" help to sharpen the poem's [imagery](#) and ideas. In stanza 1, for example, Hughes describes how his mother and aunt appear to him after death, growing taller and framed by "feathers of flame." The sight of his mother and Miriam walking together through the afterlife is awe-inspiring; they are no longer flesh and blood, but instead seem to be woven into the fabric of the cosmos. It's an astonishing concept, but one that can be a little hard to picture! A well-placed simile at the end of stanza one helps connect this description to a spectacle readers might be more familiar with—the aurora borealis, or the Northern Lights:

The work of the cosmos,
Creation and destruction of matter
And of anti-matter
Pulses and flare, shudders and fades
Like the Northern Lights in their feathers.

Picture the Northern Lights, and one sees a colorful curtain of light rippling across the sky. This, Hughes says, is what it looks like as the "work of the cosmos" plays across the women's "feathers." The simile calls to mind something mysterious and ethereal, even "otherworldly." And yet, the Northern Lights are a *real* thing. Hughes's vision of these ghosts and the afterlife is thus grounded in a profound appreciation for the natural world.

In stanza 2, Hughes uses a simile to describe the ways his mother liked to "wear" different worries and anxieties, trying them on "Like pairs of shoes, or one dress after another." This simile fills the reader in a bit more about Hughes's mother, or at least about how *Hughes* thinks about his mother—namely that she busied herself with "unending worry" and was committed to fretting about her sons.

This line also calls the reader's attention back to the issue of

appearances. In line 18, Hughes's mother told Miriam to look at the "water-line" stained on her dress; here, in line 35, Hughes imagines her trying on and casting off new fears and concerns like items of clothing. This suggests that there may be something insincere or shallow about the way Hughes's mother liked to obsess about her sons. Perhaps the construction of this simile, in which one thing is substituted for another, even hints at the poem's concluding lines, where Hughes writes that his mother sometimes treated him as a poor substitute for his older brother.

The poem's final simile compares Hughes to "the shadow cast by this approach." Somewhat [ironically](#), Hughes becomes the only real shadowy presence in the poem: the simile conveys how insubstantial he seems beside his brother, who overshadows him.

Where Simile appears in the poem:

- **Line 14:** "Like the Northern Lights in their feathers."
- **Line 35:** "Like pairs of shoes, or one dress after another"
- **Lines 50-52:** "My mother's face is glistening / As if she held it into the skyline wind / Looking towards me."
- **Line 55:** "As if I were the shadow cast by this approach."

METAPHOR

The poem's [metaphors](#), like its [similes](#) and striking [imagery](#), make the poem more urgent, emotional, and accessible to readers.

In lines 7-8, metaphor helps paint Hughes's vision of the afterlife:

In the perpetual Sunday Morning
Of everlasting [...]

This place isn't *heaven*, exactly—at least not in the biblical sense. But it's something like it. Sunday is the Lord's Day in Christianity. Like the Sabbath, it's a joyful day associated with peace and tranquility. Wherever Hughes's mother and sister are, it's pretty idyllic. It's also a place of "perpetual" rebirth, where Hughes's mother and Miriam can come back to life, at least in Hughes's mind's eye.

A second metaphor in stanza 2 makes another reference to faith and religion:

[...] Now my mother
Shows her the rosary beads of unending worry,

In these lines (33-34), Hughes compares his mother's endless worries to a string of rosary beads, prayer beads some Catholics use to count or recite prayers. This suggests that, in life, Hughes's mother was devoted to her worries and never seemed to run out of things to worry about. It seems like her

sons were often the subject of those anxieties. Because rosary beads are held in the hand and may be gripped tightly, this metaphor suggests that her fears and concerns for her sons were a kind of religion to Hughes's mother—and that her influence may have been a little suffocating. Her contentment hinged on just "sitting at the window [...]" Knowing they were somewhere." According to Hughes's mother, that hasn't changed even in death. She is still apart from her sons, and they are still out there, living without her.

A final metaphor in stanza 4 brings Hughes's complicated relationship with his mother and brother into sharper focus:

She is using me to tune finer
Her weeping love for my brother, through mine,

Hughes suggests that his mother is using him like an instrument to "tune" her sad adoration of his brother. He's just a kind of poor approximation of her favorite son. It's as if Hughes's mother's "weeping love" is being refined as it passes through him, made smoother and more potent. Despite talking so much about how her happiness resides in her sons, it seems that, in Hughes's mind, *one* of those sons matters a whole lot more than the other. This metaphor suggests that despite the strength of his mother's love, Hughes still feels used, as if she can't simply love him as he is. This knowledge, in turn, colors and complicates his memories of his mother and his love for her.

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Lines 7-8:** "In the perpetual Sunday Morning / Of everlasting,"
- **Line 34:** "Shows her the rosary prayers of unending worry,"
- **Lines 53-54:** "She is using me to tune finer / Her weeping love for my brother, through mine,"



VOCABULARY

Diary page (Lines 3-4) - In British English, "diary" refers specifically to an appointment book or datebook.

Jotted (Lines 4-5) - Quickly written down.

Larks (Lines 9-10) - Songbirds known for their melodious singing. Larks sing very early in the morning and as such are often [symbols](#) of daybreak. They're also sometimes used to represent Christ and the movement from the earthly to the spiritual realm. As such, they're a fitting bird for "the perpetual Sunday Morning / Of everlasting."

Cosmos (Line 10) - By this, Hughes means the universe's constant, cyclical processes of creation and destruction.

Anti-matter (Lines 11-12) - A physics term referring to

particles with the opposite electric charge of ordinary matter. By mentioning both "matter" and "anti-matter," Hughes emphasizes the balanced, cyclical nature of the "work of the cosmos." Creation and destruction, life and death, are all intertwined.

Northern Lights (Lines 13-14) - An atmospheric phenomenon also known as the aurora borealis, the Northern Lights are colorful waves of light that can be seen at night in high latitudes. Hughes mentions the Northern Lights to illustrate what the "work of the cosmos" looks like as it surrounds his mother and aunt in the afterlife.

Piping (Lines 16-17) - High-pitched or flutelike.

Gorge (Lines 16-17) - A narrow canyon or gully with steep sides.

Heather (Lines 22-23) - A flowering plant native to the moors and bogs and Europe.

Madonna-like (Lines 30-32) - Like a devotional image of the Virgin Mary. Miriam appears pure and innocent as she listens to her sister describe her life.

Rosary prayers (Line 34) - Rosary prayers are a sequence of prayers; worshippers use a string of knots or beads to count out each prayer. In metaphorically comparing his mother's "unending worry" to this string of prayers, Hughes suggests that his mother's worries were, indeed, many, and that she found comfort in counting them out.

Brink (Lines 43-44) - An edge or steep verge. Hughes's mother and Miriam are standing at the edge of the afterlife, looking out at him.

Sheer (Line 48) - This can refer to something being either very great in power and intensity or to something being faintly see-through and semi-transparent. Both meanings actually work in this line. The implication is that, after many years in the afterlife, Miriam has become something more elemental, her body transparent flame rather than flesh and blood.

- The third has 9 lines
- And the final two stanzas are tercets made up of three lines each

The result is a kind of shaggy poem, one that passes freely back and forth between Hughes's memories of his mother and his vision of the afterlife. The long second stanza, in particular, pulls the reader into the details of Hughes's mother's life. Like Miriam, who is listening "Madonna-like with pure wonder," the reader finds themselves absorbed in the mother's recollections. It's almost as if, in stanza 2, Hughes's mother hijacks the poem as she goes on and on about her life.

But Hughes gets things back under control in the final two stanzas and fits his ideas into neat tercets. It's possible that the poem's form is telling the reader something about how grief works—how sometimes it looms large and threatens to take over everything. After reflecting on his mother, Hughes has to work hard to discipline his feelings and pinpoint why her loss feels so complicated. Perhaps the tercets are his way of getting those feelings back under control and rationalizing his grief.

METER

"Anniversary" uses [free verse](#), meaning that it has no strict meter. Instead, it has an easy, conversational rhythm. The poem uses frequent [enjambment](#), which pulls the reader down the page, while frequent [caesurae](#) prevent things from ever tumbling out of control. The poem's loose, lyrical rhythms are appropriate for a speaker who is lost in thought remembering a loved one.

Very occasionally, the speaker lapses into a formal [iambic](#) meter. An iamb is a foot with two syllables arranged in an unstressed-stressed pattern (da-DUM). Iambic meter sounds very natural in spoken English, so these lines don't necessarily stick out. This meter does, however, underscore the weight of simple, profound statements, as in line 5:

"Ma died | today" | —and there | they are.

Just as the speaker's brother recorded his mother's death in the plainest possible terms, the speaker is equally straightforward and direct about how their mother and Miriam appear in their mind's eye. Each half of the line is equal in terms of stressed beats. It's perfectly balanced, suggesting that even though the speaker's mother is dead, it's *equally true* that the speaker sees her clear as day.

RHYME SCHEME

"Anniversary" doesn't use a [rhyme scheme](#). Because it also lacks a [formal meter](#), Hughes's poem is an example of [free verse](#). Rhyme usually adds emphasis to the final words of a line, but this poem has a very natural, almost conversational flow. Since the poem describes an imagined conversation taking place between the speaker's mother and his aunt Miriam, that



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"Anniversary" is an [elegy](#): Hughes is somberly reflecting on his mother on the anniversary of her death. Unlike many elegies, however, the poem doesn't end on a particularly hopeful note. On the contrary, "Anniversary" leaves the reader with a sense of Hughes's disappointment and bitterness at being overshadowed in his mother's eye by his brother.

The poem also doesn't follow a standard structure. Each [stanza](#) is a different length:

- The first has 14 lines
- The second has 27 lines

choice seems fitting. It's also pretty typical of Hughes's work. Although Hughes was interested in sound (and plays with sound in other ways), he rarely used strict rhyme schemes in his poetry.



SPEAKER

"Anniversary" is an autobiographical poem, and it's fair to consider Ted Hughes himself its speaker.

Throughout the poem, Hughes contemplates the loss of his mother, his aunt Miriam's early death, and his fraught relationship with his older brother. Although he's writing about loss, Hughes doesn't seem to be overly emotional. He notes the date of his mother's death matter-of-factly and is unsurprised at how vividly he sees her and Miriam "strolling together" in some realm beyond the living. Hughes is writing about his own family (at least, an imagined version of them), but he doesn't let his own grief eclipse the main subject at hand: his mother and her life experience.

In this poem, then, Hughes attempts to be primarily a restrained observer (though readers can likely sense the love, bitterness, grief, and resentment bubbling beneath the poem's surface). He's sketching out details of his mother's life, and even though it seems as if their relationship wasn't always easy, it's clear that he's still working hard to understand her. The long second stanza, for example, is an exercise in writing from her point of view. Hughes adopts his mom's voice to illustrate how her own happiness was intimately intertwined with the hopes, fears, and desires she had for her sons. For example, he imagines her in the afterlife telling Miriam, "Truly / Wonderful it was, day after day, / Knowing they were somewhere."

As the poem's speaker, Hughes is very aware of just how complicated his relationship with his mother was. He seems to recognize his own ambivalence—perhaps he even subtly acknowledges that this isn't how a bereaved son is expected to feel. By the end of the poem, though, Hughes's focus seems to shift. Instead of just being concerned with the loss of his mother, Hughes hones in on a lifelong rivalry with his brother, who, as far as the reader can tell, is still alive. As the poem's speaker, Hughes is dealing with competing feelings for different family members. His grief is complicated by his frustration with his mother's "weeping love for my brother," and the knowledge that his brother was so obviously the favorite son.



SETTING

The setting of "Anniversary" moves seamlessly between Hughes's vision of the afterlife and his memories of Yorkshire, England. As Hughes imagines it, life after death is a "perpetual Sunday Morning," endless and serene. Larks are singing overhead, their voices echoing forever "in their orbits."

It's peaceful, but it isn't quaint: all around, fierce cosmic energy is on display as matter is created and destroyed. "The work of the cosmos" is an awe-inspiring spectacle woven into the fabric of the afterlife. The dead have wings of fire and ethereal displays of light and color ripple through their feathers like the "Northern Lights." They still look human, but they're no longer fixed inside their bodies. Hughes's mother's voice, for example, "comes, piping, / Down a deep gorge of woodland echoes" as though it were a stream swiftly tumbling through a forest. Similarly, she "Grows taller," while Miriam fades into a translucent pillar of flame.

In Hughes's mind, the afterlife seems to be a place of fluidity and flux where matter is changed and transformed. It's positioned somewhere just beyond the realm of the living: Miriam and Hughes's mother reach the end, "the brink / Of the starry dew," some sort of cliff or vantage point from where they can look down at him. But Hughes's mother also refers to a reservoir and fields of heather as well as to a house with a view of the horizon. Likewise, Hughes calls up the memory of the British countryside, when he walked "a mile over fields and walls" in the direction of his mother. His vision of the afterlife reflects the idyllic countryside of his native Yorkshire and is grounded in memories of that place.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

The English poet Ted Hughes (1930-1998) is one of the best-known writers of the 20th century. His 1957 debut, *The Hawk in the Rain*, was a shock to the system of British poetry; it was seen as a challenge to poets of the older generation, who often wrote with greater emphasis on formal structure and emotional restraint.

Hughes grew up in West Riding, Yorkshire, a relatively rural part of England, and he cultivated an early interest in the natural world that would influence his poetry. Hughes was both reverent and unsentimental about nature, seeing it not just as a source of wisdom and beauty (as 19th-century Romantics like [William Wordsworth](#) often did), but also as an environment full of [instinctive violence](#) and danger.

Hughes was also captivated by the idea of mythological archetypes, including the theme of the rival brothers. He was obsessed with the idea of a ghostly double, which he seems to have found in his older brother, Gerald Hughes, who left home at 18 before emigrating to Australia. The last two stanzas of "Anniversary" point to the lasting hurt his mother suffered in Gerald's absence as well as to Hughes's complicated relationship with his brother.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Hughes was born in Mytholmroyd in Yorkshire, England, in

1930. This poem offers just a glimpse of the rural landscape of his upbringing. "Anniversary" is a particularly personal poem for Hughes, as it deals directly with his family. Hughes's mother, Edith Hughes, died on May 13, 1969, when Hughes was 39 years old. This was a devastating time for Hughes, who was already reeling from the sudden loss of his romantic partner, the poet Assia Wevill, and their four-year-old daughter, Shura. It's possible that Hughes obliquely references their deaths, as well as the loss of his first wife, the poet [Sylvia Plath](#), in lines 27-29:

She is scattering the red coals with her fingers
To find where I had fallen
For the third time. [...]

Edith appears in several of her son's poems from this period. She was a tremendous influence on Hughes, and she also played an important role in the family lore. After the death of her older sister, Miriam, Edith claimed she had developed the extraordinary ability to predict if and when another family member was about to die. Hughes wrote:

[...] through the years, just before any member of her family died, Miriam would appear at my mother's bedside. But as the years passed, her ghost changed. She became brighter and taller. "Gradually," said my mother, "she has turned into an angel." [...] My mother described her as being made of flame. As if she were covered with many-colored feathers of soft, pouring flame.

The [imagery](#) Hughes uses in "Anniversary" closely reflects Edith's own description of Miriam's ghost. Although Edith believed herself able to foretell tragedy, she often described Miriam's spirit as a comforting presence. Perhaps, in the wake of so many terrible losses, Hughes was also looking for consolation when he conjured his aunt and his mother on the page.

Hughes's life and work via the Academy of American Poets. (<https://poets.org/poet/ted-hughes>)

- [The Art of Poetry with Ted Hughes](#) — An interview with the poet which appeared in *The Paris Review* shortly after the publication of "Anniversary." (<https://www.theparisreview.org/interviews/1669/the-art-of-poetry-no-71-ted-hughes>)
- [Portraits of Ted Hughes](#) — The National Portrait Gallery offers a variety of looks at the poet throughout his career. (<https://www.npg.org.uk/collections/search/person/mp06453/edward-james-ted-hughes>)
- [Ted Hughes's Obituary](#) — The New York Times's 1998 obituary of Hughes explores the poet's controversial life and career. (<https://www.nytimes.com/1998/10/30/books/ted-hughes-68-a-symbolic-poet-and-sylvia-plath-s-husband-dies.html>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER TED HUGHES POEMS

- [A Memory](#)
- [A Picture of Otto](#)
- [Bayonet Charge](#)
- [Cat and Mouse](#)
- [Football at Slack](#)
- [Hawk Roosting](#)
- [Relic](#)
- [Roe-Deer](#)
- [Snowdrop](#)
- [Telegraph Wires](#)
- [The Harvest Moon](#)
- [The Horses](#)
- [The Jaguar](#)
- [The Other](#)
- [The Thought Fox](#)
- [Wind](#)



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MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [Gerald Hughes's Obituary](#) — An obituary for Ted Hughes's older brother, which sheds light on the Hughes's family life and the relationship between the rival siblings. (<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2016/aug/24/gerald-hughes-obituary>)
- [More About Ted Hughes](#) — A short overview of Ted